

Disability Benefits & Income

Living with a disability that limits work? Federal programs provide monthly income and health coverage — and you can save without losing benefits. Below are the main national starting points. Tick the box once you've checked each one.

⚠ BEFORE YOU START

The two main programs are SSDI (based on work history) and SSI (based on low income). Applying is free — never pay upfront to file. If you're denied at first (many are), you can appeal, and free help exists.

1 Monthly Income Benefits

The two main federal disability income programs.

- ☐ **SSDI — Social Security Disability Insurance**
Monthly benefits if you worked and paid Social Security but can no longer work due to disability.
→ www.ssa.gov/benefits/disability 1-800-772-1213
- ☐ **SSI — Supplemental Security Income**
Monthly payments for people with disabilities (and seniors) who have little income or resources.
→ www.ssa.gov/ssi

2 Health Coverage

Disability benefits open the door to health coverage.

- ☐ **Medicaid & Medicare**
SSI usually brings Medicaid; SSDI brings Medicare after a waiting period. Check your eligibility.
→ www.medicaid.gov/medicaid/eligibility/index.html

3 Apply & Appeal

How to file — and what to do if you're denied.

- ☐ **Apply for Disability**
Apply online, by phone, or in person. Gather medical records to support your claim.
→ www.ssa.gov/applyfordisability
- ☐ **Free Help & Appeals**
Many are denied first time. Free legal aid and disability advocates can help you appeal; most lawyers only get paid if you win.
→ www.lawhelp.org

4 Save Without Losing Benefits

Special accounts let you build savings safely.

☐ **ABLE Accounts**

Tax-advantaged savings that don't count against SSI/Medicaid limits, for people disabled before age 46.

→ www.ablenrc.org

☐ **Work Incentives (Ticket to Work)**

Try working without immediately losing benefits, through free SSA work programs.

→ choosework.ssa.gov 1-866-968-7842

⚠ WATCH OUT FOR

Never pay a large upfront fee to “get approved” for disability — reputable disability attorneys are only paid a capped amount if you win. Be wary of anyone guaranteeing approval.

★ A TIP THAT HELPS

Apply as soon as your condition prevents work, and keep detailed medical records — they're the heart of a strong claim. If denied, appeal; many people are approved only after appealing with help.

NEED HELP WHERE YOU LIVE?

Need help where you live?

This guide covers national programs. For local disability advocates and help applying or appealing, use the personalized AI search or ask in the Questions area.

MY NOTES — WHO I CALLED, WHEN, AND WHAT THEY SAID
